1.2 President of the People?

When you're considered an outsider and achieve something big, people expect great things of you. That was the position Andrew Jackson was in when he won the presidency, and now all eyes were on him.

MAIN IDEA Andrew Jackson rose from humble beginnings to become a U.S. president who symbolized a new brand of democracy.

FROM HARDSHIP TO HERO

Andrew Jackson was the first president who didn't come from a wealthy Virginia or Massachusetts family. In fact, he was born into poverty in 1767 and grew up in North Carolina. His father died before his birth, leaving his mother to raise him and his brothers.

During the American Revolution, young Jackson served as a messenger for the Continental Army. British soldiers discovered what he was doing and took him prisoner. While Jackson was being held, a British soldier ordered the boy to clean his boots. Jackson refused, and the soldier slashed him with his sword. Jackson also contracted smallpox and survived, but his mother and brothers weren't as lucky. He was an orphan by the age of 14.

Despite his hard childhood, Jackson achieved great success. He moved to the Tennessee frontier and became a lawyer in 1787. He practiced law in the small but growing town of Nashville and met his future wife, Rachel Donelson Robards, while boarding with her family. Later, he made a successful run for Congress. In 1804, Jackson purchased a



The Cabildo – Louisiana State Museum, New Orleans

In 1815, wearing this uniform coat, Jackson led the American victory at the Battle of New Orleans, which ended the War of 1812. Jackson is also wearing the coat in the 1817 portrait by Ralph E.W. Earl, shown on the opposite page. What details in the coat might indicate that the person wearing it is a general?

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425-acre farm, later known as the Hermitage, where he built a plantation and used enslaved people to labor in his fields.

When the War of 1812 broke out between the United States and Great Britain, Jackson served as a general in command of soldiers from Tennessee. After crushing the British at the Battle of New Orleans, Jackson became a national hero.

A CLEAN SWEEP

Jackson's success was crowned by his election as president of the United States in 1828. About 30,000 people witnessed his inauguration in March 1829. But he endured the ceremony with a heavy heart. During the campaign, some of the mudslinging had been directed at his wife's reputation. When she died of a heart attack three months before her husband's inauguration, Jackson believed the personal attacks had caused her death.

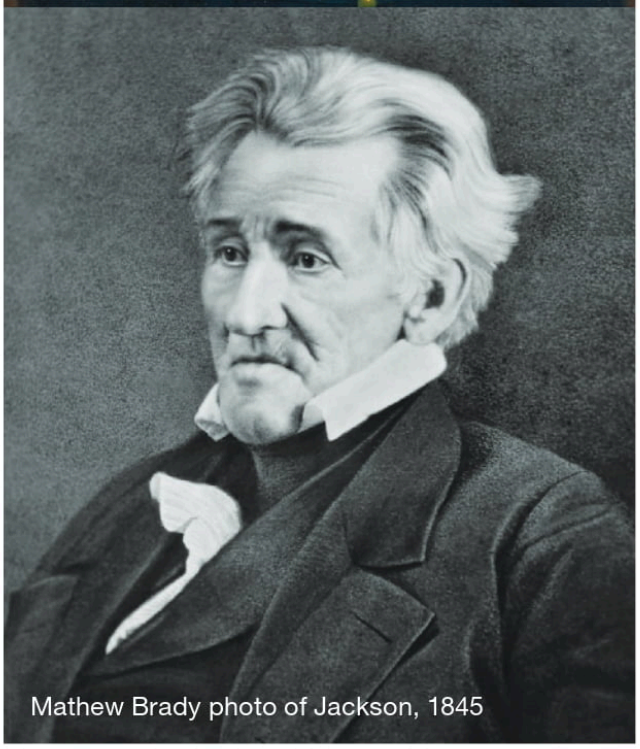
Once he took office, however, Jackson assumed the presidency with enthusiasm and began carrying out the government reforms he'd promised to make during his campaign. First, Jackson replaced many of Adams's government officials with his own supporters. These appointees included newspaper editors who had been loyal to Jackson during the presidential campaign.

Critics claimed that what he'd done was corrupt. They believed Jackson was using the appointments to assume greater control of the federal government. But Jackson defended his actions by pointing out that completely removing officials from time to time prevents any one party from maintaining a stranglehold on government. The practice of rewarding political backers with government jobs became known as the **spoils system**, and it continues today. The term comes from the saying, "to the victors belong the spoils [goods or benefits] of the enemy." In this case, the "spoils" were the political positions Jackson had given to his supporters.

Controversy over appointments was just one of the problems Jackson faced early in his presidency. Soon he would find himself in a battle over taxes and states' rights that threatened to tear apart the Union.



Portrait of General Andrew Jackson, 1817



Mathew Brady photo of Jackson, 1845

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What challenges did Andrew Jackson face growing up?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did Jackson differ from all preceding presidents?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Do you think Jackson was right to initiate the use of the spoils system to appoint government officials? Support your opinion.

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